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SETUP
Student Services App

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1. Introduction

Product Vision

As students of SETU, we aim to develop a dedicated, accessible student services product, that unifies the apps and utilities common to daily student life. The ideal SETU Personalised (SETUP) application integrates both existing and new educational and social features alike, giving staff & students more control over their educational experience, in real time, in one place.

To gain a better understanding of what we want SETUP to be, we investigated three existing products; Maynooth University App, xTiles & Studo. While each differs in scope and functionality, all serve as a reference point for different features SETUP implements.

A1. Maynooth University App

1. FOR Staff and students enrolled in Maynooth University [1]

2. WHO are interested in a service unique to the institution, with app features can be easily tailored to the needs of their userbase, such as:

- Campus Map Navigation
- MU Eduroam Setup
- University News & Events
- MU Clubs & Socs
- Commuting Info
- MU Eats

3. Released in 2022 with over 1k+ users, the **Maynooth University App** is a cross-platform **student services tool** students may avail of for its variety of educational and social features.[2]

It takes inspiration from similar purpose apps such as'Studo' [3], which integrates existing features from several apps into the one front-end interface.

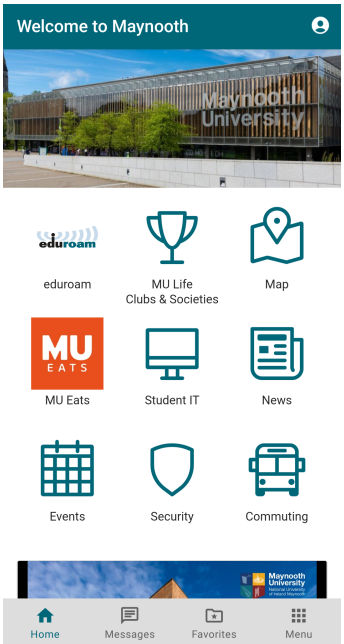

Fig 1. MU App Hompeage

When balancing reliance on third-parties, it's important to be realistic about development cost, time and ability. Often, it can be more redundant than useful to try reinvent the existing available tools,such as Moodle's learning environment, especially as a smaller team.

4. THAT prioritises a student life & learning centric approach to the platform. Supported by the college, it's free of costly subscription charges in order to have full functionality of the app.

5. UNLIKE alternatives such as Moodle, MU App's comprehensive design distinguishes itself from the more generalised alternatives on the market. By mitigating the reliance on third-party providers, MU has more flexibility in adapting to the needs of its users.

6. MAYNOOTH UNIVERSITY APP's design approach provides students with a service personalised to their institution. This close relationship between users, institution and developers makes it difficult for generalised competitors to fulfill the needs of its userbase as fluently.

The product serves as a reference point for similar SETUP development, given the comparable scale, resources and services ideal for both.

A2. xTiles

1. FOR Students and creative professionals, especially those seeking accessibility features.

2. WHO aim to visualise their workflow with a variety of templates and widgets.

3. XTILES is a **workspace and visual productivity platform** that is aimed towards daily planning, personal tasks, note-taking and project management.[4]

4. THAT Features drag-and-drop like moving texts, links and images that make it easy to rearrange your workspace. It is user-friendly and suitable for creating schedules and weekly study schedules. As a target demographic, students are provided special offers on paid plans.

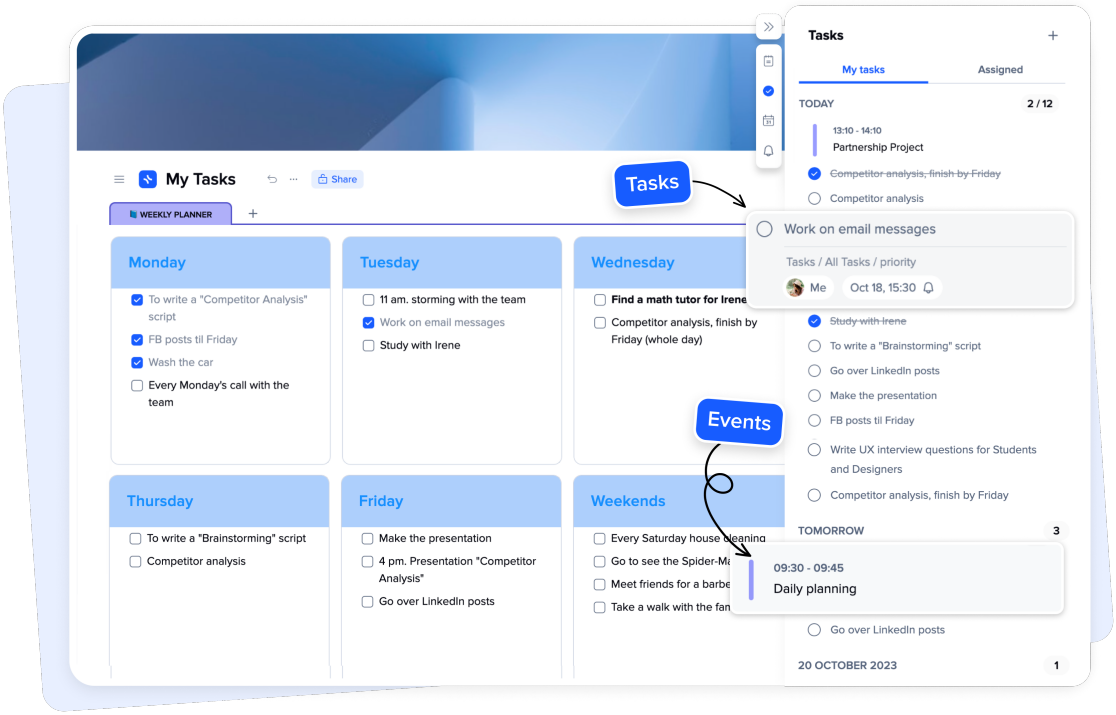

Fig 2. xTiles Interface

5. UNLIKE document-esque formatted alternatives, e.g. Microsoft Office 365, xTiles offers an at-a-glance overview of its users tasks, schedules and notes. First time users may find the UI of accessibility features provided by xTiles to be less intimidating for this reason. The lack of download or specific device requirements also make acess of the platform convenient, provided a user has reliable internet access.

6. XTILES design approach succeeds not on any one feature alone, but rather by providing its own visual spin on the popular features found across existing similar platforms;

- **Flexible** visual workspace where you can customize to your own needs.
  (Enables the user to add texts, images, links, etc.)
- **Real-time** multi-user support for collaboration.
  (Teams can work on a board together.)
- **Utilities** for making plans, brainstorms and organising.
- **Cross-platform**, accessible through multiple devices.
- **Integration** with other applications e.g. Google Calendar.
  (Allows events and deadlines to be synced across project.)

- **Templates** provided, giving users the option of customisation without the expectation of starting from scratch.
- Visually appealing and **intuitive UI** improves upon **accessibility** and engagement for ADHD, low-vision, etc.

When taking inspiration for the SETUP app, it's worth considering the reported limitations[5] of the platform:

- Lacking in **offline support**, making it unreliable for those without consistent internet.
- The large variety in tools can be offputting to new users without **clear instructions**.
- **Limited free plan** often pushes users into paid alternatives to access what some may expect to be basic features.

It's difficult for any project to predict how any given feature will be received or what challenges it may bring to development. For this reason, being receptive to user feedback at all stages of development can be hugely beneficial in the long-term.

A3. Studo

1. FOR Staff and students of any university eligible for use with Studo.

2. WHO are seeking a convenient all-in-one interface to access a range of student life and learning services.

3. STUDO is an app that provides a variety of **student and campus services**. The company partners with & supplies software across 60+ universities, with over 500k downloads on the mobile app version of its Studo student service.[3]

4. THAT,focuses on combining existing, but separate, platforms into one front-end application. e.g. SETU Timetable, student grades & Moodle access.

5. UNLIKE separated, smaller scope student services, which develop their platforms independently, e.g. Moodle/Outlook. Studo is not in competition with so much as it serves to integrate existing developed services into a convenient front-end interface for its user.

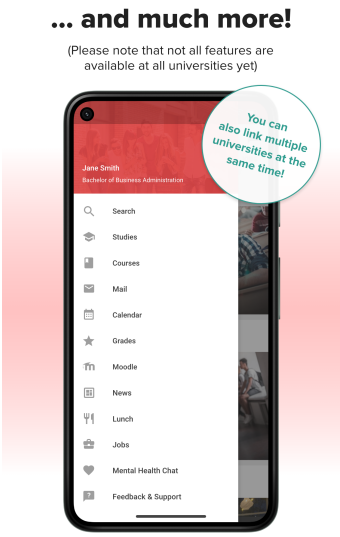

Fig 3. Studo Menu

6. STUDO distinguishes itself by focusing development on the following features:

- **All-in-one** interface for daily university/on-campus services (email, calendar, grades, timetables)
- **Real-Time** polls and push alerts
- **Easy integration** for existing records and student information
- **Accessible** course and grade overview. (highlights dates for assignments and uploads)
- **Synced** cross-platform from multiple devices
- University news feeds, vouchers, lunch menus

However, when considering its design for a SETUP application, note it's often criticised for:

- **Limited** or **redundant** features, many of which are heavily admin restricted.
- **Lack of customisation** options for students

- Chat feature between students is heavily moderated and **overly censorious**.
- 2FA and login features are unreliable, reported difficulty in students connecting accounts among other **integration issues**.

Features

Taking inspiration from the product vision cases above, we can use our analysis to form the foundation for the SETUP App's feature categories.

Many listed features exist in some form within the SETU website's student hub, meaning the infrastructure for supporting timetables, lab results, etc. will not have to be majorly altered to support the app.

Academic
Services related to a student's specific course.

- *Timetables*
  Timetable provided based on the details of a logged in user, eliminating the need to manually input details by default as seen on the existing timetable webpage.
- *Exam/Lab Results*
  Using moodle integration, congregate a students relevant lab results in the one place. Provide useful stats such as overall average, overall percent for a given lab, etc.
- *Academic Calendar*
  Relevant university events, allow editing for individual students to add their own information similar to a study planner.
- *To-Do/Notes Tool*
  Utility for quick notes, tracking of various deadlines set by Moodle, templates for study schedules.
- *Examinations*
  Upcoming student examinations, room details, etc.
- *Moodle Integration*
  In a similar fashion to Studo, integrate Moodle as a tab within the app directly.
- *Email Integration*
  Allow users to connect several email accounts, e.g. outlook, gmail, to the one inbox.

Student Life
Services related to a student's social life, not necessary course specific.

- *Clubs & Societies*
  Information on various clubs and societies, alongside options to pay membership.
- *News & Events*
  University updates, events, news. Opt-in follow to be notified for specific niches e.g. Computer Science Department events.
- *Transport Schedules*
  Bus/train commute info, could be integrated with services such as TFI.
- *Library*
  Options to reserve/renew loaned books, organise study pods, check opening hours, etc.
- *Campus Map*
  Integrated Google Map of the SETU campus, options to add custom markers, notes, etc. to buildings.

Support Services
University support services/utilities, grants & fee management.

- *Grants & Fees*
  Grant application info, student fee details, may be ideal to include information on external grants such as SUSI.
- *Disability Support*
  Contact info and associated systems for the disability service.
- *Counselling Services*
  Booking and associated systems for the counselling service.
- *Computer Services*
  Booking and associated systems for the computer service.
- *Eduroam & Printing Utilities*
  Wifi and printer setup.

User Experience
Broad considerations when implementing the above services.

- *Intuitive Design*
  Menus and layout should be concise and visually clear. Integrated first or third-party features should not be unnecessarily bloated or redundant.
- *Cross-Platform Sync*
  Sync a user across devices, (desktop, phone, etc.) and the SETU website when internet is available.
- *Offline Access*
  Allow users to save info such as timetables, lab results, etc. for use offline.
- *Feedback & Reports*
  Users should be able to report bugs, criticism or suggestions on improving the app.
- *Accessibility Tools*
  Settings for low-vision, colour-blind, screen-readers, etc.
- *Free and Efficient*
  Assuming development is supported by SETU, advertisements or paid premium memberships should not be expected. Exceptions for society memberships, student tuition fees.
- *Real-time Notifications*
  Users may opt-in to various push notifications, updates, etc.
- *GDPR compliant; data secure*
  Use of 2FA, privacy options, secure cloud storage handled by services like Cloudflare, Google Drive. Payment services also trusted to a third party such as stripe/google pay.

2. Personas

Definition

A user persona imagines a specific type of user for a given platform. e.g. SETUP, a student services app, may consider students, lecturers, and/or guests. Product expectations may vary depending on user background, education and skillset.

By conceptualising the types of users this product seeks to attract; personas assess what features are best to proritise. It also suggests what features may require further development, or scrapping entirely, in order for the product to be suitable for its demographics.

1. PLACEHOLDER, a COURSENAME student

incl. relevant job/course background details persona goals/ambitions
educational/technical skillset; what would make ui intuitive?
relevance of persona to SETUP app

2. PLACEHOLDER, a COURSENAME lecturer

incl. relevant job/course background details persona goals/ambitions
educational/technical skillset; what would make ui intuitive?
relevance of persona to SETUP app

3. Maria Angelo, Parent, Nursing Student

Maria Angelo, 46 years old, mother of two daughters. She is a nurse who works in a local hospital, aiding patients in need of care. She graduated out of nursing school when she was 22 years old in the Philippines. By 30 years old she got the opportunity to work in Ireland, where she met her lovely husband 2 years after. They live in the suburb with their daughters, a 12 years old and and a 14 year old. One who is starting first year of secondary school while the other is in third year. Her husband, who is an accountant, works in a business company and is rarely around the house as he's always busy with his 9 to 5 job. Maria has been in the nursing field for 23 years and she wants to specialize in a different area where she needs a certification.

She decides to go back to college and start studying again. Maria is a busy woman, now that she's back in education, works in the hospital and sometimes would go overtime. She packs lunch for her daughters and drops them off to school. Her husband would alternate around giving their daughters lifts. After she finishes college, she picks up her daughters up and would go straight to work in the evenings. Maria loves keeping herself busy but from time to time she would forget what to do next. She would miss deadlines for her assignments and would have to contact her lecturers to have an extension. She doesn't make schedules, she would rather write the information on the palm of her hand. When Maria realised that she developed additional stress into her life, she is willing to start being organise.

With the help of SETUP, she can create her schedules, check lists of her tasks and additional information. This will assist her time schedule, as it includes an automated timetable specifically for the user. There's a board for the user to write up their personal to-do list and it traces deadlines that is set by Moodle. She can email her lecturers through the app as well as receiving them. Instead of going through different applications for peculiar tasks, she can do it all in one application.

The app is set to handle these jobs. The built in integrations and neat GUI will help her stay on top and well arrange to set personal schedules, tick off her to-do lists and communicate with her lecturers with deadlines.

4. PLACEHOLDER, a COURSENAME student with accessibility concerns

incl. relevant job/course background details persona goals/ambitions
educational/technical skillset; what would make ui intuitive?
relevance of persona to SETUP app.

3. Scenarios

Definition

etc. etc.

Scenario 1

etc. etc.

Scenario 2

etc. etc.

Scenario 3

Mario Angelo is a 46 year old mother of two daughters. She works as a nurse and is also a mature student in SETU. She's always busy every weekday dropping her daughters to and from school, going to her classes midday and then working in the evenings. She loves being occupied but she lacks time management. Sometimes, it's difficult for her to keep on track when she needs to submit her assignments and would miss the deadlines. Since Maria and her husband alternate times to pick up their daughters, Maria would forget and her husband would remind her, leaving her daughters waiting more outside of school hours or either making them late to school by a minute. This also affects Maria by being late to her own class in the mornings.

With the help of SETUP, she can benefit from the app by scheduling her day. The To-Do and Notes Tool icon, she can track her deadlines, and jot down notes to write before her day starts. The app lets you add a template to add schedules and times. This is easy for Maria, so she knows what time of the day to get things done.

If she misses a deadline, SETUP has an email integration where it allows the user to connect to several email accounts to one inbox. It enables her to receive notifications from that application. It supports her so she doesn't have to go from app to app.

This improves Maria's organising skills. Now she doesn't need to remind herself but with the support of the application, it lets her keep on track. She is able to send emails to lecturers just incase she needs to have extensions and also receive the email all in one application.

4. User Stories

Definition

etc. etc.

User Story 1

etc. etc.

User Story 2

etc. etc.

User Story 3

As a student who wants to get more involved on campus, I want to:

- View a list of clubs and societies that are available in my college
- Be able to sort the list according to my interests and preferences
- Register for clubs and societies through the app
- Get updates and notifications on meetings and events in the society
- Communicate with other members of the clubs and societies through the app

User Story 4

As a student who finds it difficult to manage their time, I want to:

- Have the ability to plan my tasks and classes
- Get reminders regarding future deadlines and exams

- Be able to set goals and monitor my progress towards them
- Have the ability to connect with other students for study groups and support
- Use the app to access resources and materials for my courses easily

User Story 5

etc. etc.

User Story 6

etc. etc.

5. Prototype

Definition

etc. etc.

Personal Reflection

My primary role in the project was to document and write up about an example of an app for the project, creating user scenarios and user stories. Everyone in the group separated the work equally and sometimes there would be two people working on the same section to help each other out. I also contributed to making the UML diagrams such as the class diagram. I've also teamed up with one of the group members to help create the activity diagram as well. I've learned how to use Visual Paradigm to create the diagrams. By using the lecturer's example of the UML diagrams, I was able to understand how to design the diagrams and how it is represented in Visual Paradigm. I found it to be a useful tool and it has a lot of features that helped me what the shapes and symbols mean. It was a bit confusing at the start since it has a lot of options, but once I got used to it, it was easy to use. Creating the user scenarios and user stories were fun to do as it allowed me to be creative and think about how the app would be used in real life.
Our biggest challenge was keeping the group on track and keeping everyone consisten with the work. We addressed this by chatting with each other on a regular basis on Discord and making sure that we get the work done before the deadline. It was difficult to keep on track as everyone has different schedules and there would be exams and other assignments to do, but we managed to get the work done on time. Choosing Latex as our documentation tool was a learning experience.For myself, Latex was a new tool that I rarely used before, especially using it in VSCode while connected to GitHub. The start-up was difficult as I was unfamiliar with the syntax and spent a lot of time trying to figure out things. But one of my group member had experience with Latex and helped me out with the syntax and how to use it. Once I got passed the learning curve, I found it to be very useful and professional for documentation. It allowed us to create a well-structured and formatted document that looks great. I also learned how to use GitHub to collaborate with my group members and keep track of the changes we made to the document.
In the future project I would like to improve my time management skills and communication with my group members. I think that would help us to keep on track and make sure that everyone is on the same page with the work. I also want to learn more about Latex and how to use it more efficiently for documentation. Overall, I enjoyed working on this project and learned a lot from it.

Tools Used

description, ease of use, brief.

Media (URLs, Screenshots)

sample of relevant urls, screenshots.

Studo Website : https://studo.com/en
Studo Reviews : https://chrome-stats.com/d/com.moshbit.studo

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